

LAUGHING KOOKABURRA

Dacelo novaeguineae

Laughing kookaburras are famously vocal. A first loud, chuckling laugh spreads into a loud chorus from several birds, the staccato notes echoing through the Australian bush. “Laughing jackass” was a popular nickname for this large-headed, short-legged bird; another, “bushman’s clock”, reflects the regularity of calls at dawn and dusk. Its nest is an unlined hollow in a tree stump or in a hole excavated with its bill in a termite mound. Like other kingfishers, its three to five eggs are pure white. If food is short, the final egg is small and the resultant weak chick is likely to be killed by its stronger siblings. Adult laughing kookaburras form life-long pair bonds, but are helped at the nest by up to five immature birds from previous years, and all may incubate the eggs and then brood and feed the chicks. This species is widespread and relatively common, but recent wildfires in Australian woodland have seriously affected many populations.



SIZE 41–47 cm (16–18½ in)

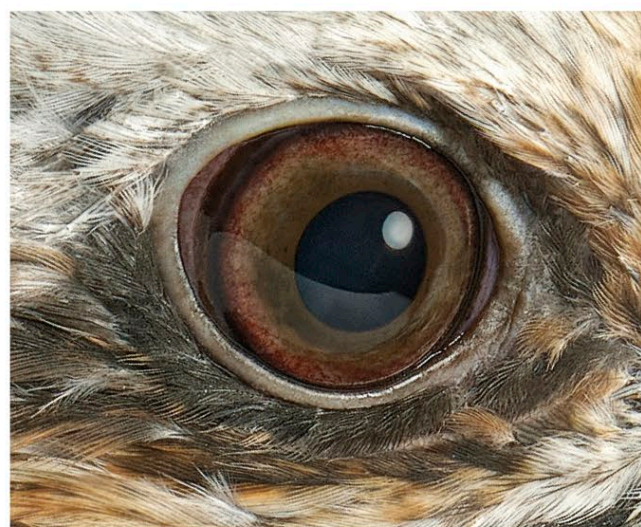
HABITAT Open, bushy woodland and eucalypt forest

DISTRIBUTION Eastern Australia, introduced in other parts of Australia and New Zealand

DIET Lizards, snakes, small mammals, insects, worms, snails, and other invertebrates

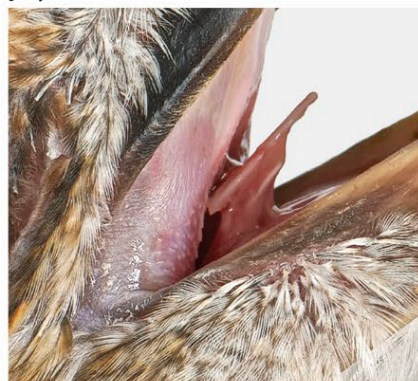
EYE >

A sensitive area of the retina in each eye allows exceptionally sharp vision. The laughing kookaburra moves its head to align a second sensitive area in each eye to give binocular vision when searching for prey below.



✓ TONGUE

The broad, pointed tongue sits neatly inside the deep lower mandible. Sticky with mucous, it has a small “hook” at the rear, and helps to manipulate and swallow wriggling or muscular prey items.



✓ FOOT

As with other kingfishers, the long outer toe and middle toe are fused together. The very short leg gives a secure, upright stance on a perch, but means the laughing kookaburra can only shuffle when on the ground.



TAIL ✓

The laughing kookaburra's tail is long for a kingfisher. In flight, the tail is spread wide revealing all 12 feathers.



outer tail feathers have more white bands than inner feathers

< NOSTRIL

An open nostril high at the base of the bill minimizes the risk of clogging by sand or mud. The long, bristly feathers behind it help protect the eye.



WING ^

Short and broad, the wing is curved into an aerofoil: the thick, muscular inner “arm” tapers to flat, blade-like flight feathers behind and at the tip.